

Overview: Chunking into 1-Step Instructions

Chunking transforms overwhelming multi-step instructions into manageable single steps. Instead of giving three instructions at once, you deliver one, wait for completion, then give the next. This dramatically reduces cognitive load for pupils who struggle to hold multiple instructions in working memory.

When to Use This Strategy

- Pupil completes first step then looks lost
- Frequently asks "What do I do now?"
- Starts wrong task after multi-step instruction
- Waits for peers to start, then copies them

Step-by-Step Guide

1 Identify multi-step moments

Before the lesson, note where you usually give 2+ instructions together. Task setup is the classic one.

Teacher says: N/A - this is prep

Tip: Write these moments on a Post-it as a reminder.

2 Break into single steps

"Get your book, open to page 42, answer questions 1-3" becomes three separate instructions.

Tip: Each instruction should require only one action.

3 Agree a completion signal

Decide how you'll know step one is done before giving step two. This could be the pupil looking at you, putting their pen down, or giving a thumbs up.

Teacher says: "When you've done that, look at me and I'll tell you the next step."

Tip: Agree this in advance so it becomes automatic.

4 Position yourself

Stay close enough to see the completion signal and deliver the next instruction without delay. Don't hover—just be ready.

Tip: Being too far away creates a delay that breaks momentum.

5 Deliver with consistent language

Use the same format each time. "First..." Wait. "Now..." Wait. "Next..." The predictability helps.

Teacher says: "First, get your exercise book." [Wait] "Now, open to page 42." [Wait] "Read question 1."

English Example: Writing a paragraph about a character

Year 8 class writing about Macbeth. One pupil working at KS1 level needs to write 3 sentences.

Step 1: Get ready

Teacher: Say: "Get your exercise book and open to a clean page."

Pupil: Opens book. Looks at teacher.

Step 2: First sentence

Teacher: Say: "Write: Macbeth is a..." Point to word bank with character words.

Pupil: Copies sentence starter. Chooses word from bank. Writes sentence.

Step 3: Check and continue

Teacher: Say: "Read your sentence to me." Then: "Good. Now write: He feels..."

Pupil: Reads sentence aloud. Writes second sentence.

Maths Example: Solving simple equations

Year 9 solving equations. Pupil working at KS2 level needs to solve $3x = 12$.

Step 1: Identify the operation

Teacher: Point to equation. Say: "What is happening to x ? Is it being multiplied or divided?"

Pupil: Says "multiplied" (or teacher guides to answer).

Step 2: Do the inverse

Teacher: Say: "To undo multiply, we divide. Divide both sides by 3." Point to where to write.

Pupil: Writes $\div 3$ on both sides.

Step 3: Calculate

Teacher: Say: "What is 12 divided by 3?" Wait. "Write $x =$ your answer."

Pupil: Calculates (using manipulatives if needed). Writes $x = 4$.

Science Example: Setting up a practical

Year 7 setting up Bunsen burner. Pupil working at KS1 level needs safety support.

Step 1: Safety first

Teacher: Say: "Put on your safety goggles." Wait for goggles to be on properly.

Pupil: Puts on goggles. Looks at teacher.

Step 2: Connect gas

Teacher: Say: "Push the rubber tube onto the gas tap. Push it on firmly."

Pupil: Connects tube. Tugs gently to check secure.

Step 3: Check airhole

Teacher: Point to airhole. Say: "Turn this collar so the hole is closed." Demonstrate.

Pupil: Closes airhole. Looks at teacher for next instruction.